ENTERTAINMENT

THE BETTER HALF

An Indian adaptation of *The Good Wife*, ***The Trial*** marks Kajol's streaming debut

In the past six months, Indian streaming platforms have bet big on adaptations. Netflix tapped Ashim Ahluwalia to helm *Class*, the glossy Indian adaptation of the hit Spanish series *Elite*. Sandeep Modi created, co-wrote and directed *The Night Manager* for Disney+ Hotstar. And Suparn S. Varma went on to direct two adaptations for both Netflix and Disney+ Hotstar. In March, he helmed *Rana Naidu*, the Indian remake of *Ray Donovan*, alongside creator Karan Anshuman, and then, three months later, came the opportunity to direct *The Trial*, the Indian adaptation of *The Good Wife*, the cult CBS legal drama that boasted Ridley Scott as an executive producer.

There were several reasons why Varma, who also co-directed the masterful second season of *Family Man*, was keen on directing *The Trial*. For one, it would allow him to examine the changing nature of relationships, friendships and marriages from an Indian context, serving as an update on the source material itself. "*The Good Wife* came out 14 years ago. The world has changed a lot since then. There are more grey zones now," Varma says over a phone call. The second thing that the filmmaker was interested in reimagining was the depiction of Indian courtrooms, considering a large chunk of episodes revolved around court cases. "It's nice to have a dialogue like *'tareekh pe tareekh* [date after date]' in a courtroom drama, but that was a different era. It was important to me that *The Trial* updated the courtroom drama to modern-day sensibilities," says Varma.

> The Trial offers Kajol plenty to chew on, letting her underscore the dichotomy of the state of modern women in a conservative society

Still, the bigger attraction was getting Kajol on board to play Noyonika Sengupta, a homemaker who returns to her career in law after her famous

